Jordi Laguarta Soler

PhD candidate, MIT EECS · Earth Intelligence Lab · Cambridge, MA

laguarta@mit.edu
jordi-laguarta-soler.com
Google Scholar · GitHub · LinkedIn

I build multimodal ML systems end to end for domains where expert labels are scarce: foundation models as annotators, self-supervised pretraining, explainable predictions, and national-scale inference evaluated under distribution shift. At MIT and Microsoft Research, I have applied them to high-stakes problems in health and food security: screening for COVID-19 and Alzheimer's from coughs and speech, and mapping crops across entire countries. I also lead research on the reliability of foundation-model benchmarks in Earth observation, and have mentored five undergraduate, master's and PhD students during my PhD. PhD expected February 2027; seeking research and applied scientist roles, open to forward-deployed and research-product work.

EXPERIENCE

MIT Earth Intelligence Lab · PhD candidate (advisor: Prof. Sherrie Wang) Sep 2022 – present

- **National 10 m crop-type map of India** (first author, in preparation). Built a VLM data engine in which Gemini 3.1 Pro labelled 728,490 street-level images (90.2% agreement with agronomists), then distilled it into a classifier on frozen AlphaEarth embeddings for national inference in under 4 hours on Earth Engine.
- **Thailand crop-type map** (first author, AAAI 2024). Zero-shot GPT-4V labels on Street View images replaced expert annotation as the training signal; the map reaches 92% accuracy, within one point of the expert-supervised map.
- **Benchmark reliability**. Leading research on whether Earth-observation benchmarks separate geospatial foundation models by more than seed noise.
- Mentored five undergraduate, master's and PhD students.

Microsoft Research · Research intern, Seattle May 2024 – Aug 2024

- **Self-supervised multimodal foundation model** for radar, optical and land-cover satellite time series, working with the AI for Agriculture and AI for Industry teams. Designed the encoder architecture, built its 20 TB data-streaming pipeline, optimised its throughput and ran distributed multi-GPU pretraining.

MIT Auto-ID Lab · Research assistant (supervisor: Dr. Brian Subirana) Feb 2020 – Sep 2021

- **COVID-19 screening from phone-recorded forced coughs** (first author, IEEE OJEMB 2020; 700+ citations). Transferred acoustic-biomarker CNN encoders, pretrained on separate audio tasks, to COVID-19 detection: AUC 0.97, with 98.5% sensitivity at 94.2% specificity on the official-test subgroup of a 5,320-subject dataset, and 100% sensitivity on asymptomatic subjects.
- The cough-screening technology was licensed by MIT for COVID-19 pre-screening (Nov 2020).
- **Alzheimer's screening from spontaneous speech** (first author, Frontiers in Computer Science 2021). The same acoustic-biomarker encoders reach 93.8% accuracy on the ADReSS test set from raw audio.
- Both models output explainable per-patient saliency maps that track disease progression over time.
- Set up clinical data collaborations with the Government of Catalonia's Department of Health (Spain), the Universidad de Guadalajara (Mexico) and Ospedale Luigi Sacco (Italy) for forced-cough recordings from PCR-tested patients.

EY-Parthenon · Strategy consulting intern, Geneva Sep 2021 – Jan 2022

- Built a playbook of technology-led sustainability strategies for consumer-goods, retail and agribusiness firms.

Earlier Sep 2017 – Jan 2020

- Data scientist, Nutrino Health (later acquired by Medtronic): improved a food-image classifier with weak labels.
- Lead data scientist, ADLA (start-up): built a computer-vision recommendation chatbot.
- Lead software engineer, InAGlobe Education: co-built a student–NGO technical-project matching platform.

PUBLICATIONS

1. **J. Laguarta Soler**, S. Cheng, E. Liao, S. Wang. An open 10-meter multi-crop map of India from street-level imagery and vision-language models. *Manuscript in preparation*, 2026.
2. **J. Laguarta Soler**, T. Friedel, S. Wang. Combining deep learning and street view imagery to map smallholder crop types. *Proc. AAAI* 38(20):22202–22212, 2024.
3. **J. Laguarta**, F. Hueto, B. Subirana. COVID-19 artificial intelligence diagnosis using only cough recordings. *IEEE Open Journal of Engineering in Medicine and Biology* 1:275–281, 2020.
4. **J. Laguarta**, B. Subirana. Longitudinal speech biomarkers for automated Alzheimer's detection. *Frontiers in Computer Science* 3:624694, 2021.
5. B. Subirana, F. Hueto, P. Rajasekaran, **J. Laguarta**, et al. Hi Sigma, do I have the coronavirus? Call for a new artificial intelligence approach to support health care professionals dealing with the COVID-19 pandemic. *arXiv:2004.06510*, 2020.

Research featured in BBC News, The Economist and the World Economic Forum (2020), and MIT News (2020, 2024).

EDUCATION

MIT · PhD, Electrical Engineering and Computer Science — Sep 2022 – Feb 2027 (expected)

Cornell Tech · MEng, Computer Science · merit scholarship — Sep 2020 – May 2022 (leave of absence, fall 2021)

Imperial College London · BEng, Electronic and Information Engineering — Oct 2016 – May 2019
Specialization in machine learning

TEACHING

Harvard Extension School · Invited lecturer, Introduction to Artificial Intelligence — Sep 2020

SKILLS

Machine learning	Multimodal learning, foundation models, vision-language models, VLM data engines and model-generated supervision, self-supervised pretraining, cross-modal distillation, evaluation science and benchmark reliability, distribution shift, explainability, national-scale inference, computer vision, remote sensing and satellite time series, audio and speech
Tools	Python, PyTorch, TensorFlow, Google Earth Engine, Vertex AI and Google Cloud, distributed multi-GPU training, high-throughput data streaming, SLURM, SQL, C/C++
Languages	Catalan, Spanish, English, French